

» Transposition and accidentals

When transposing a melody that includes accidentals, we must ensure that the accidentals are also transposed. The transposed melody might include the exact same accidentals as the melody at concert pitch, but this is not always the case. It depends on the interval of transposition.

Concert pitch (in A minor)

D# at concert pitch

D# at concert pitch

Transposed up a major second (in B minor)

Transposed up a major second to E#

Transposed up a major second to E#

◁ Beethoven's "Für Elise"

Shown here is the opening of Beethoven's "Für Elise" at concert pitch (in A minor), and transposed up a major second (in B minor). In both cases, the melody has sharps and a natural in the same place.

Concert pitch (in C major)

F# at concert pitch

Transposed down a perfect fifth (in F major)

Transposed down a perfect fifth to Bb

◁ Haydn's "Surprise" Symphony

This extract from Haydn's "Surprise" Symphony at concert pitch (in C major) includes the accidental F#. Transposed down a perfect fifth, with the melody now in F major, this accidental becomes Bb.

Concert pitch (in B minor)

A# at concert pitch

F# at concert pitch

Transposed up a minor third (in D minor)

Transposed up a minor third to C#

Transposed up a minor third to A#

△ Schubert's "Unfinished" Symphony

This extract at concert pitch includes the accidentals A# and F#. When transposed, A# becomes C#, and F# becomes A#.